中国各地的饮食

从北方的面到南方的早茶

Food Across China

From Northern Noodles to Southern Morning Tea

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 4 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 中国很大，各个地方的气候、环境和历史都不一样，所以人们吃的东西也很不一样。有人说，在中国，每走几百公里，饭菜的味道就会变。中国人常说“八大菜系[1]”，意思是八个有名的地方菜：鲁菜[2]、川菜[3]、粤菜[4]、苏菜[5]、闽菜[6]、浙菜[7]、湘菜[8]和徽菜[9]。当然，中国的地方菜远远[10]不止[11]八种。这篇文章就带你去看看中国各地的饮食[12]有什么特点。

北方的面，南方的米

2 中国北方和南方最大的区别之一，是主食[13]不同。

1 八大菜系 *bā dà càixì* the Eight Great Cuisines
2 鲁菜 *Lǔcài* Shandong cuisine
3 川菜 *Chuāncài* Sichuan cuisine
4 粤菜 *Yuècài* Cantonese cuisine
5 苏菜 *Sūcài* Jiangsu cuisine
6 闽菜 *Mǐncài* Fujian cuisine
7 浙菜 *Zhècài* Zhejiang cuisine
8 湘菜 *Xiāngcài* Hunan cuisine
9 徽菜 *Huīcài* Anhui cuisine
10 远远 *yuǎnyuǎn* far (more)
11 不止 *bùzhǐ* more than
12 饮食 *yǐnshí* food and drink, diet
13 主食 *zhǔshí* staple food

China is a huge country. Its regions differ in climate, landscape and history, so people in different places eat very different things. Some say that in China the taste of the food changes every few hundred kilometres. Chinese people often speak of the "Eight Great Cuisines", eight famous regional styles: Shandong, Sichuan, Cantonese, Jiangsu, Fujian, Zhejiang, Hunan and Anhui cooking. Of course, China has far more than eight regional cuisines. This article takes you on a tour to see what makes the food of each part of China special. 1

Noodles in the North, Rice in the South

One of the biggest differences between northern and southern China is the staple food. 2

2 北方冬天冷，雨水[1]比较少，适合种小麦[2]，所以北方人主要吃面食[3]，比如面条、饺子、包子和馒头[4]。南方天气暖和，雨水多，适合种水稻[5]，所以南方人每天都离不开米饭。

3 在北方，面食的种类非常多。山西[6]人特别会做面，据说山西的面食有几百种。其中最有名的是刀削面[7]：厨师[8]一手拿着一大块面，一手拿着刀，很快地把面一片一片削[9]到开水里。兰州[10]牛肉面[11]也很有名，当地人说，一碗好的牛肉面，汤要清[12]，萝卜[13]要白，辣椒油[14]要红，香菜要绿，面要黄。

4 南方人不但吃米饭，还用大米[15]做出很多别的食物，比如米粉[16]、年糕[17]和粽子[18]。

1 雨水 *yǔshuǐ* rainfall
2 小麦 *xiǎomài* wheat
3 面食 *miànshí* wheat-based foods
4 馒头 *mántou* plain steamed buns
5 水稻 *shuǐdào* rice (the crop)
6 山西 *Shānxī* Shanxi (province)
7 刀削面 *dāoxiāomiàn* knife-shaved noodles
8 厨师 *chúshī* chef, cook
9 削 *xiāo* to shave, to pare
10 兰州 *Lánzhōu* Lanzhou
11 牛肉面 *niúròumiàn* beef noodle soup
12 清 *qīng* clear
13 萝卜 *luóbo* radish
14 辣椒油 *làjiāoyóu* chili oil
15 大米 *dàmǐ* rice (grain)
16 米粉 *mǐfěn* rice noodles
17 年糕 *niángāo* rice cake
18 粽子 *zòngzi* zongzi, sticky rice wrapped in leaves

Northern winters are cold and there is less rain, which suits wheat, so northerners mainly eat wheat-based foods such as noodles, dumplings, stuffed buns and plain steamed buns. The south is warm and rainy, ideal for growing rice, so southerners can hardly go a day without it. 2

In the north there is a huge variety of wheat-based dishes. People in Shanxi are especially good at making noodles; it is said the province has several hundred kinds of wheat dishes. The best known is knife-shaved noodles: the cook holds a big lump of dough in one hand and a knife in the other, and quickly shaves the dough strip by strip straight into boiling water. Lanzhou beef noodle soup is famous too. Locals say that in a good bowl the broth is clear, the radish white, the chili oil red, the coriander green and the noodles yellow. 3

Southerners don't just eat plain rice; they turn it into many other foods, such as rice noodles, rice cakes and zongzi. 4

在广西[1]和湖南[2]，很多人早上最喜欢吃一碗热米粉[3]。当然，现在交通方便了，北方人也常吃米饭，南方人也爱吃面条，这种区别已经不像以前那么大了。

川菜[4]：又麻[5]又辣

说到辣，很多人第一个想到的就是四川[6]菜，也叫川菜。川菜最大的特点是“麻”和“辣”。“辣”来自辣椒[7]，“麻”来自花椒[8]。花椒吃到嘴里，舌头[9]会有一种麻麻的感觉，好像有电一样。很多外国朋友第一次吃花椒，都觉得很奇怪，可是吃多了以后，就会慢慢喜欢上这种味道。

1 广西 *Guǎngxī* Guangxi
2 湖南 *Húnán* Hunan
3 米粉 *mǐfěn* rice noodles
4 川菜 *Chuāncài* Sichuan cuisine
5 麻 *má* numbing (spicy)
6 四川 *Sìchuān* Sichuan
7 辣椒 *làjiāo* chili pepper
8 花椒 *huājiāo* Sichuan pepper
9 舌头 *shétou* tongue

In Guangxi and Hunan, many people's favourite breakfast is a hot bowl of rice noodles. Of course, now that travel is easy, northerners often eat rice and southerners love noodles too, so the difference is not as big as it once was. 4

Sichuan Cuisine: Numbing and Hot

Speaking of spicy food, the first thing many people think of is Sichuan cooking, known as chuancai. Its two great features are "ma", numbing, and "la", hot. The heat comes from chili peppers, the numbing from Sichuan pepper. When you bite on Sichuan pepper your tongue tingles, almost as if there were electricity in it. Many foreigners find it very strange the first time, but after a while they slowly come to love the taste. 5

6 有名的川菜[1]有麻婆豆腐[2]、宫保鸡丁[3]、水煮鱼[4]和回锅肉[5]。成都[6]和重庆[7]的火锅[8]更是有名。一大锅[9]红红的汤，里面放满了辣椒[10]和花椒[11]，大家围着锅坐，把肉和菜放进去煮[12]，一边吃一边聊[13]，非常热闹。

7 有意思的是，辣椒并不是中国本来就有的。辣椒来自美洲[14]，大概在明朝[15]后期[16]才传到中国。也就是说，川菜变得这么辣，其实只有几百年的历史。除了四川[17]人，湖南[18]人也特别能吃辣。不过，湘菜[19]的辣和川菜不太一样，它常常是又香又辣，还带一点儿酸，但是不太麻[20]。

1 川菜 *Chuāncài* Sichuan cuisine
2 麻婆豆腐 *mápó dòufu* mapo tofu
3 宫保鸡丁 *gōngbǎo jīdīng* kung pao chicken
4 水煮鱼 *shuǐzhǔyú* fish boiled in chili oil
5 回锅肉 *huíguōròu* twice-cooked pork
6 成都 *Chéngdū* Chengdu
7 重庆 *Chóngqìng* Chongqing
8 火锅 *huǒguō* hotpot
9 锅 *guō* pot
10 辣椒 *làjiāo* chili pepper
11 花椒 *huājiāo* Sichuan pepper
12 煮 *zhǔ* to boil
13 聊 *liáo* to chat
14 美洲 *Měizhōu* the Americas
15 明朝 *Míngcháo* the Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
16 后期 *hòuqī* later period
17 四川 *Sìchuān* Sichuan
18 湖南 *Húnán* Hunan
19 湘菜 *Xiāngcài* Hunan cuisine
20 麻 *má* numbing (spicy)

Famous Sichuan dishes include mapo tofu, kung pao chicken, fish boiled in chili oil and twice-cooked pork. Even more famous is the hotpot of Chengdu and Chongqing. A big pot of bright red broth full of chilies and Sichuan pepper sits in the middle; everyone sits around it, cooking meat and vegetables in it, eating and chatting in a lively crowd. 6

Interestingly, the chili pepper is not native to China. It came from the Americas and only reached China in the later part of the Ming dynasty. In other words, Sichuan food has only been this hot for a few hundred years. Besides the Sichuanese, people from Hunan are also famous for handling chili. But Hunan heat is different: it is fragrant and hot, often a little sour, without much of the numbing tingle. 7

粤菜[1]和早茶[2]

8 粤菜就是广东[3]菜，在世界上可能是最有名的中国菜。这是因为很早以前，就有很多广东人到国外生活，他们把家乡菜带到了世界各地。粤菜的特点和川菜[4]差不多相反：它不太辣，味道比较清淡[5]，非常重视食材是否新鲜。广东人认为，好的食材不需要太多调料[6]，简单地蒸[7]一下，就能吃出它本来的味道。

9 在广州[8]和香港[9]，很多人有“喝早茶”的习惯。早上或者中午，家人和朋友一起去茶楼[10]，点一壶[11]茶，再点几笼[12]点心[13]，慢慢吃，慢慢聊[14]，有时候一坐就是两三个小时。点心的种类很多，比如虾饺[15]、烧卖[16]、叉烧包[17]和肠粉[18]。

1 粤菜 *Yuècài* Cantonese cuisine
2 早茶 *zǎochá* morning tea (a dim sum meal)
3 广东 *Guǎngdōng* Guangdong
4 川菜 *Chuāncài* Sichuan cuisine
5 清淡 *qīngdàn* light, mild
6 调料 *tiáoliào* seasonings
7 蒸 *zhēng* to steam
8 广州 *Guǎngzhōu* Guangzhou
9 香港 *Xiānggǎng* Hong Kong
10 茶楼 *chálóu* teahouse
11 壶 *hú* pot (measure word)
12 笼 *lóng* steamer basket (measure word)
13 点心 *diǎnxin* dim sum, snacks
14 聊 *liáo* to chat
15 虾饺 *xiājiǎo* shrimp dumplings
16 烧卖 *shāomai* shaomai dumplings
17 叉烧包 *chāshāobāo* barbecue pork bun
18 肠粉 *chángfěn* rice noodle rolls

Cantonese Food and Morning Tea

Yuecai is Cantonese food, probably the best-known Chinese cooking in the world. That is because many Cantonese people moved abroad long ago and took their home cooking all over the world. Cantonese cooking is almost the opposite of Sichuan: it is not very hot, its flavours are light, and it cares a great deal about fresh ingredients. The Cantonese believe good ingredients need little seasoning: steam them simply and you taste what they really are. 8

In Guangzhou and Hong Kong many people have the habit of "drinking morning tea". In the morning or at noon, family and friends go to a teahouse together, order a pot of tea and a few baskets of dim sum, and eat and talk at leisure, sometimes for two or three hours. There are many kinds of dim sum, such as shrimp dumplings, shaomai, barbecue pork buns and rice noodle rolls. 9

每样[1]点心[2]都很小，放在小小的竹[3]笼[4]里，所以大家可以多点几样，一起分着吃。

广东[5]人吃的东西种类特别多，有人开玩笑说，天上飞的、地上走的、水里游的，广东人都敢吃。这句话虽然有点儿夸张[6]，但是也说明了粤菜[7]的食材非常丰富。另外，广东人很喜欢煲汤[8]，很多家庭会花好几个小时慢慢煮[9]一锅[10]汤，他们相信这样的汤对身体很好。

南甜北咸[11]

中国人常用“南甜北咸”这四个字来说南北[12]口味[13]的不同。这句话当然不完全准确，但是说出了一个大概的情况。

1 样 *yàng* kind (measure word)
2 点心 *diǎnxin* dim sum, snacks
3 竹 *zhú* bamboo
4 笼 *lóng* steamer basket (measure word)
5 广东 *Guǎngdōng* Guangdong
6 夸张 *kuāzhāng* exaggerated
7 粤菜 *Yuècài* Cantonese cuisine
8 煲汤 *bāotāng* to slow-cook soup
9 煮 *zhǔ* to boil
10 锅 *guō* pot
11 南甜北咸 *nán tián běi xián* “sweet south, salty north”
12 南北 *nánběi* north and south
13 口味 *kǒuwèi* taste, flavour

Each portion is small and comes in a little bamboo steamer, so everyone can order several kinds and share them. 9

The Cantonese eat an especially wide range of things; people joke that whatever flies in the sky, walks on land or swims in water, the Cantonese will dare to eat it. That is an exaggeration, but it shows how rich the range of Cantonese ingredients is. The Cantonese also love slow-cooked soups: many families spend hours simmering a pot of soup, believing it is very good for the body. 10

Sweet South, Salty North

Chinese people often sum up the difference in taste between north and south in four characters: nan tian bei xian, "sweet south, salty north". The saying is not entirely accurate, of course, but it captures the general picture. 11

12 上海[1]、苏州[2]和无锡[3]一带[4]的菜，常常比较甜。比如上海的红烧肉[5]，要放不少糖，颜色红亮，吃起来又甜又香。无锡的排骨也很甜。很多北方人第一次去上海吃饭，都会奇怪："怎么每个菜都放糖？"

13 北方菜呢，常常比较咸，酱油[6]和盐放得比较多，味道也比较重。东北菜分量[7]很大，一盘菜常常够好几个人吃，比如锅包肉[8]和地三鲜[9]。山东[10]菜，也就是鲁菜[11]，是八大菜系[12]中历史最长的之一，以前皇宫[13]里的很多菜都受到了鲁菜的影响。

14 山西[14]人爱吃醋[15]是出了名的，有人说，山西人吃什么都要放一点儿醋。

1 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
2 苏州 *Sūzhōu* Suzhou
3 无锡 *Wúxī* Wuxi
4 一带 *yīdài* area, region
5 红烧肉 *hóngshāoròu* red-braised pork
6 酱油 *jiàngyóu* soy sauce
7 分量 *fènliàng* portion size
8 锅包肉 *guōbāoròu* crispy sweet-and-sour pork
9 地三鲜 *dìsānxiān* fried potato, aubergine and pepper
10 山东 *Shāndōng* Shandong
11 鲁菜 *Lǔcài* Shandong cuisine
12 八大菜系 *bā dà càixì* the Eight Great Cuisines
13 皇宫 *huánggōng* imperial palace
14 山西 *Shānxī* Shanxi (province)
15 醋 *cù* vinegar

The food of Shanghai, Suzhou and Wuxi is often rather sweet. Shanghai's red-braised pork, for example, takes quite a lot of sugar; it is a glossy red and tastes sweet and rich. Wuxi's spare ribs are sweet too. Many northerners eating in Shanghai for the first time wonder, "Why is there sugar in every dish?" 12

Northern food, on the other hand, tends to be saltier, with more soy sauce and salt and stronger flavours. Dishes in the Northeast come in big portions — one plate is often enough for several people — such as guobaorou, crispy sweet-and-sour pork, and disanxian, fried potato, aubergine and green pepper. Shandong cooking, Lucai, has one of the longest histories of the eight great cuisines, and many dishes of the old imperial palace were influenced by it. 13

Shanxi people's love of vinegar is well known; some say they add a little to everything they eat. 14

14 豆腐脑[1]是一个很好玩的例子。很多北方人吃咸的豆腐脑，上面放酱油[2]和别的调料[3]；很多南方人却吃甜的，只放糖或者糖水。每年网上都有人为这个问题争论，就像端午节[4]的时候争论粽子[5]是甜的好还是咸的好一样。

饭桌上的习惯

15 和很多西方国家不一样，中国人吃饭的时候，一般不是每人一份，而是把几个菜放在桌子中间，大家一起吃。所以，点菜的时候要考虑每个人的口味[6]，最好有肉、有鱼、有蔬菜[7]，再来一个汤。很多饭店用大圆桌，中间还有一个可以转的玻璃[8]台，这样每个人都能方便地夹[9]到每一道菜。

1 豆腐脑 *dòufunǎo* tofu pudding
2 酱油 *jiàngyóu* soy sauce
3 调料 *tiáoliào* seasonings
4 端午节 *Duānwǔjié* Dragon Boat Festival
5 粽子 *zòngzi* zongzi, sticky rice wrapped in leaves
6 口味 *kǒuwèi* taste, flavour
7 蔬菜 *shūcài* vegetables
8 玻璃 *bōli* glass
9 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)

Tofu pudding is a fun example of regional taste. Many northerners eat it savoury, topped with soy sauce and other seasonings, while many southerners eat it sweet, with just sugar or syrup. Every year people argue about it online, just as they argue at the Dragon Boat Festival over whether zongzi should be sweet or salty. 14

Customs at the Table

Unlike in many Western countries, Chinese meals are usually not one plate per person: several dishes are placed in the middle of the table and everyone shares. So when ordering you have to think about everyone's tastes; ideally there is meat, fish and vegetables, plus a soup. Many restaurants use large round tables with a revolving glass top in the middle, so everyone can easily reach every dish with their chopsticks. 15

16 用筷子也有一些规矩[1]。比如，不要把筷子竖[2]着插[3]在米饭里，因为这样看起来很像给去世的人上香[4]，会让人觉得不吉利[5]。也不要用筷子敲[6]碗，这样很不礼貌[7]。请客的时候，主人常常会给客人夹[8]菜，这是热情的表现。

17 在中国，朋友一起吃完饭，常常会抢[9]着付钱。如果这次朋友请了你，下次最好由你来请。这样你来我往[10]，朋友之间的关系就会越来越好。

18 在比较正式的饭局，座位也有讲究。一般来说，正对着门的位子[11]是给主人或者最重要的客人坐的。如果你不知道应该坐在哪里，最好等主人来安排。

1 规矩 *guīju* rules, etiquette
2 竖 *shù* upright
3 插 *chā* to stick in
4 上香 *shàngxiāng* to offer incense
5 吉利 *jílì* lucky
6 敲 *qiāo* to knock
7 礼貌 *lǐmào* polite
8 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)
9 抢 *qiǎng* to scramble (to do sth)
10 你来我往 *nǐ lái wǒ wǎng* give and take
11 位子 *wèizi* seat

Chopsticks also come with some rules. For example, don't stand your chopsticks upright in a bowl of rice: it looks like incense offered to the dead and is considered unlucky. Nor should you tap your bowl with your chopsticks, which is rude. When hosting, the host often puts food into the guests' bowls, a sign of warm hospitality. 16

In China, when friends finish a meal together, they often compete to pay the bill. If a friend treats you this time, it is best if you pay next time. With this give and take, friendships grow stronger and stronger. 17

At more formal dinners, the seating has its rules too. Generally, the seat directly facing the door is for the host or the most important guest. If you don't know where to sit, it is best to wait for the host to seat you. 18

街头[1]小吃

19 除了饭店里的菜，中国的街头小吃也非常有意思。早上，很多人在路边买一个煎饼果子[2]或者几个包子，一边走一边吃，就去上班了。到了晚上，夜市[3]里有烤串[4]、炒饭[5]、臭豆腐[6]和各种甜品，人很多，非常热闹。

20 臭豆腐是一种很特别的小吃，闻起来很臭[7]，吃起来却很香。很多人第一次不敢吃，可是尝[8]过一次以后，就再也忘不了[9]它的味道。冬天的北京街头，常常能看到卖糖葫芦[10]的人。糖葫芦是把山楂[11]穿在一根竹签[12]上，外面包上一层糖，吃起来酸酸甜甜的，大人和孩子都喜欢。

21 西安[13]也是一个小吃很多的城市。

---

1 街头 *jiētóu* street
2 煎饼果子 *jiānbing guǒzi* savoury crepe with fried dough
3 夜市 *yèshì* night market
4 烤串 *kǎochuàn* grilled skewers
5 炒饭 *chǎofàn* fried rice
6 臭豆腐 *chòudòufu* stinky tofu
7 臭 *chòu* smelly
8 尝 *cháng* to taste
9 忘不了 *wàngbuliǎo* can't forget
10 糖葫芦 *tánghúlu* candied haws on a stick
11 山楂 *shānzhā* hawthorn fruit
12 竹签 *zhúqiān* bamboo skewer
13 西安 *Xī'ān* Xi'an

Street Food

Besides restaurant dishes, Chinese street food is great fun too. In the morning, many people buy a jianbing guozi — a savoury crepe wrapped round fried dough — or a few buns at the roadside and eat on their way to work. In the evening, night markets offer grilled skewers, fried rice, stinky tofu and all kinds of sweets, and are crowded and lively. 19

Stinky tofu is a very special snack: it smells awful but tastes delicious. Many people don't dare try it at first, but once they have, they never forget the taste. On Beijing's streets in winter you often see people selling tanghulu. Tanghulu are hawthorn berries threaded on a bamboo stick and coated in a layer of hard sugar; sweet and sour, they are loved by adults and children alike. 20

Xi'an is another city full of snacks. 21

21 那里最有名的是肉夹馍[1]和羊肉泡馍[2]。肉夹馍有点儿像中国的汉堡[3]：把炖[4]得很软[5]的肉切碎[6]，夹[7]在一个烤[8]过的饼[9]里。吃羊肉泡馍的时候，客人要先自己把饼掰[10]成很小的块，然后交给厨师[11]，厨师再把它和羊肉汤一起煮[12]。很多人说，掰得越小，吃起来就越香。

结语

22 中国菜的种类实在太多了，一辈子[13]可能也吃不完。每个地方的菜，都和那里的天气、环境、历史和人们的生活习惯有关[14]。所以，了解一个地方的饮食[15]，也是了解那个地方文化的好办法。

1 肉夹馍 *ròujiāmó* meat stuffed in flatbread
2 羊肉泡馍 *yángròu pàomó* mutton soup with torn flatbread
3 汉堡 *hànbǎo* hamburger
4 炖 *dùn* to stew
5 软 *ruǎn* soft, tender
6 碎 *suì* in small pieces
7 夹 *jiā* to pick up (with chopsticks)
8 烤 *kǎo* to bake, to roast
9 饼 *bǐng* flatbread
10 掰 *bāi* to break off (with fingers)
11 厨师 *chúshī* chef, cook
12 煮 *zhǔ* to boil
13 一辈子 *yībèizi* a lifetime
14 有关 *yǒuguān* to be related to
15 饮食 *yǐnshí* food and drink, diet

The most famous are roujiamo, meat stuffed into flatbread, and yangrou 21
paomo, mutton soup with pieces of bread. Roujiamo is a bit like a Chinese hamburger: meat stewed until tender is chopped and stuffed into a baked flatbread. For yangrou paomo, diners first tear the bread into tiny pieces themselves and hand the bowl to the cook, who then cooks it with mutton broth. Many say that the smaller you tear the pieces, the better it tastes.

In Closing

There are so many kinds of Chinese food that you might not get through 22
them all in a lifetime. The food of each place is bound up with its weather, landscape, history and way of life. So getting to know a region's food is also a good way to get to know its culture.

22 下次去中国旅行，别只点你认识的菜，试试当地人最喜欢的小吃吧！

Next time you travel in China, don't just order the dishes you know — try the snacks the locals love best! 22